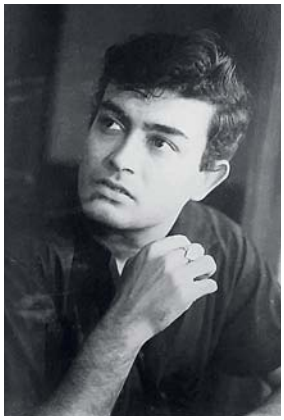
BOOKS

CAME LATE, LEFT TOO SOON

Two new books pay tribute to Sanjeev Kumar and examine the cinematic era he defined







Among the many anecdotes told across two recently published books about Sanjeev Kumar (or "Haribhai" as he was known, being Harihar Jariwala by birth), there is a poignant story about an interviewer asking the acclaimed actor why he kept playing old men. Hari's reply: a fortune-teller told him he wouldn't live long, so he tried, through his roles, to "live" an age that he would never experience firsthand.

Kumar did in fact die at 47, succumbing to a genetic heart condition in 1985 that had plagued him for years (worsened by a careless lifestyle). For the last decade and a half of his life, he was one of Hindi cinema's most canonised actors. Movie buffs well-versed with the 1970s and '80s know how admired he was by his peers, as well as by viewers who cared less for starry mannerisms and more for "character acting". But for those who came of age later, Kumar is in danger of being forgotten, or barely known. One can only imagine the opportunities he'd have got had he been around, and in good health, during the multiplex and OTT eras.

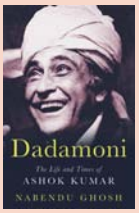
And so, any literature on the man is welcome. But here are two books by major publishers, within a year of each other—the first an "authorised biography" with inputs from the late actor's surviving family, and the second co-authored by his nephew Uday Jariwala (who is also acknowledged in the earlier book). You'd think they might represent different approaches to the actor's life and art, but that isn't quite the case. Structurally, the major difference is that *An Actor's Actor* follows a straightforward chronology, starting with Harihar Jariwala's family background and early life, before covering his peak years. On the other hand, *Sanjeev Kumar: The Actor We All Loved* is more free-flowing and playful, moving back and forth in time, including first-person accounts by Hari's friends, family and admirers.

Most of the milestones and stumbling blocks are covered: the early death of Hari's father, leaving him the oldest male child at age 11; his struggles to establish himself, first in theatre and then in film; the brief period as a lithe leading man in much-derided "stunt films"; the award-winning parts in films like *Koshish* (1972) and *Dastak* (1970).

BOOKING THE SHOW

Recent books about Hindi cinema

DADAMONI: THE LIFE AND TIMES OF ASHOK KUMAR
BY NABENDU GHOSH
SPEAKING TIGER
₹499; 232 pages



A revised edition of a precious book, and a rare instance of one notable personality (screenwriter Ghosh) paying tribute to another (Hindi cinema's first male superstar). Warm and personal, but also analytical.

